

Lawyers are working behind the scenes, while technologists are working with them

In his presentation at the same event, Keith Bergelt, CEO of Open Invention Network, said, “Right now, lawyers are working behind the scenes, and technologists are working with them. We are establishing a set of norms, and a code of conduct for copyrights as well as for patents.”

He added, “Entities like OpenChain Project and OIN (Open Invention Network) are facilitating participation from some of the smallest to the largest companies in the world so that we can all take advantage of each other’s ideas, and create a sense of novelty that otherwise would be unattainable.”

Everybody cares about the abuse of IP rights

Speaking at the meetup, Mishi Choudhary, founder and managing partner of MCA, added, “When it comes to defending the rights of Linux and open source software, people generally don’t think about sectors like banks. That has changed. Very recently, Barclays and TD Bank Group joined the OIN. Why did they do so? Everybody cares about the abuse of IP rights.”

“OpenChain has become an ISO standard and this development is extremely important. For the longest time, companies were working individually but not really coming together for licensing compliance as and when open source code development happened. But now, there are people who are there to help them out, who have put in a serious number of hours and energy into developing this standard,” she said.

The role played by open source in fighting Covid-19

Choudhary added, “2020 was a very tough year. When the pandemic began in March last year, the open source community tried to help in whatever way it could by understanding what Covid-19 was all about. That included using open data to create dashboards and apps, designing ventilators and developing protective gear.



Mishi Choudhary, founder and managing partner, MCA



Keith Bergelt, CEO of Open Invention Network



Shane Coughlan, general manager at OpenChain Project



Ramakrishna Yekulla, senior specialist solution architect with Global Partners and Alliances at Red Hat

Teams at various universities collaborated with AI firms and used open source tools to identify signs of Covid-19. The data sets were made available on GitHub.

“Lawyers played an important role when the government of India open sourced the code of its contact tracing app Aarogya Setu. It took some time to ensure that all the source code in the app was open sourced — not only the consumer side code but the server side as well. We explained to the Central government which licence would work better and how to open source the app. This shows that the community understood the importance of putting the code on GitHub to fight against the pandemic.

“Right now, there are so many licences. We also see continuous demand for different types of licences. There are certain issues which individuals or

companies feel are not being addressed by the licences available to us at present,” she concluded.

Ramakrishna Yekulla, senior specialist solution architect with Global Partners and Alliances at Red Hat also spoke at the event. He said: “India is one of the largest consumers of open source, and most users are not aware about the challenges of mixing and matching incompatible software licences. Most startups in companies are not aware of what these licences are; they see an interesting open source project that tries to solve a problem, and they just take the code and mix it to arrive at a solution.” **END** 🐧

By: Sreejani Bhattacharyya

The author is a journalist at OSFY.